wayward shot bounced over the sloping tiled roof, rebounded from somewhere and broke a window pane to the rear of the house. GJ uncle was quite perplexed and instead of scolding us, genuinely wanted to know how while playing in the front courtyard, could one hit a glass pane at the rear of the house. We also used to go swimming in the Dharna River, which was just below the Officers' Mess. All of us could easily swim a couple of breaths, learning how to tackle the current so as to not drift downstream. Once when I had cut the heel of my foot on a piece of broken glass thrown carelessly in the river by someone, all the little fishes came swarming about, drawn by the scent of blood. Oftentimes, being ravenous after our exertions, we would go to the Mess and raid the fridge, leaving nothing for the single dining-in members. They were good sports though and never complained, such is the camaraderie in the service. KB went on to become the Chief of Naval Staff and when we were Chiefs together, the years spent together as children helped immensely.

In all these years, I hardly remember studying with the kind of intensity one sees these days. Even when final or board exams were due, one did not curtail other activities. I never had to take any tuitions, except for a couple of years immediately on our return from France, to catch up on Hindi. The rest we did by ourselves or through group study. I wasn't an outstanding student, but I did manage to get a first division in the boards, with a 'distinction' in a couple of subjects. We were at 53 Anand Park, Aundh, and once the results were declared, my mother, as was customary, distributed pedhas (a sweet made of thickened milk) to close friends and neighbours. By then, I had already applied for the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, Pune, qualified in the written exam and interview, and was only awaiting my

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